A GOOD TURN
Amitabh Shah with Yuva Unstoppable children

In the summer of 2004, a 22-year-old Amitabh Shah had just got off a New York flight at Ahmedabad after a personal visit to the US. The future looked bright for him: he had already secured admission to Yale. On the nearly 18-hour flight, he caught the Shahrukh Khan starrer *Swades* to kill some time. The film ended up bringing back memories of his childhood nanny Kamalaben, who used to lovingly indulge his tantrums and take care of him. He wanted to meet her, Shah told her mother when she came to receive him at the airport.

When Shah went to Gota, the village where Kamalaben now lived, he found her sitting under a tree, old, distressed—and emaciated; she weighed just 28 kg. Her son had abandoned her, and her poverty-stricken life had drained her of all hope. Amitabh decided to shift her to an old-age home before embarking on his promising future in the United States. "When I went to drop her off at the old-age house, her roommate Sarita *ba* thought her son had sent me to take her back to him. This distressed me even more. I spread the word among my friends that this old lady would appreciate some company. So, whoever could, must visit her in their free time. To my astonishment, she got an endless stream of visitors as friends of friends joined in, and so on," says Amitabh.

It changed something in Shah. He soon told his mother that he had decided not to return to the US but stay in India and help the needy. "My parents and friends were understandably apprehensive, particularly my father. But they stood by my conviction and from there started my journey of bringing happiness through education and sanitation to the lives of millions of disadvantaged people in India," says Shah. Today, he heads Yuva Unstoppable, an NGO that has mobilised a nationwide youth volunteer network that's involved in assisting the elderly and working at slums and orphanages. Shah is also a recipient of one of the highest American awards in philanthropy: the Statue of Liberty-Ellis Island Award; in this, he shares the stage with luminaries like Bill Clinton, George Bush, Ginni Rometty, Indra Nooyi, Paula Abdul, boxer Muhammad Ali and Lee Iacocca, among others.

The journey, however, hasn't been without sacrifices. Though Amitabh did go on to pursue that MBA from Yale, he declined a Wall Street offer so that he could stay in India. Yuva Unstoppable was born in 2005. Today, it has grown to empower 6 million beneficiaries, including 4,100 schools, and has supported causes like improved sanitation in schools and villages, water availability in rural areas, solar-powered electricity, sports infrastructure, access to technology, scholarships, nutrition and spreading vaccine awareness.

It's a simple, Gandhian principle that inspires Shah, and which former US president Barack Obama too held dear—be the change you wish to see in the world. He personally ensures that the students he seeks to help are benefiting from these initiatives. And his efforts have gone a long way. A London School of Economics Impact study showed a 15 per cent improvement in attendance and a four times higher learning outcome in subjects like mathematics and science due to improved sanitation and better classrooms across villages in India. "Our vision is to impact 10,000 schools in the next five years," says Shah.

Yuva has also helped empower young girls, with a special focus on their education. During the Covid-19 pandemic, the NGO distributed free tablets to 25,000 girls. "We realised that in poor families, most of whom have just one-odd gadget that's shared by many, girl students are invariably forced to drop out of classes. We launched a project to provide tablets to girl students of such families," says Shah.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"I urge youth in the start-up ecosystem to give just 15 per cent of their wealth to charity. I want to instil philanthropy in young India"
AMITABH SHAH

The work Yuva Unstoppable has done is not just on paper. Take the case of 20-year-old Aparna Ambarapu from Hyderabad, whose father worked as a labourer in a construction company. The Yuva scholarship helped her education at IIT Hyderabad, and from there to a job at Goldman Sachs in Bengaluru. She now supports her siblings' education and the healthcare expenses of her ailing father.

For Shah, the next goal—and a crucial one—is to inspire India's youth, the up-and-coming 'wealth creators', the 'unicorn builders'. Says Shah, "I am actively urging the youth in the start-up ecosystem to contribute only 15 per cent of their wealth to charity. I have already gathered pledges worth $100 million. The direction of these projects will be decided by each donor independently. We will do only one project together. My aim is to instil the values of philanthropy in young India," he says. To begin with, they have already embarked on a Rs 60 crore project to convert 200 schools in rural Karnataka into model schools with smart digital classrooms.

In a world obsessed with personal riches and the glamour of wealth, Shah's work is a living example of the adage: no one has become poor by giving. ■